

chosen industrialists, among them being the Ambanis, the Ruia and Gautam Adani. The dissenters also accuse Modi of abetting corruption in sectors like water conservation and power. Another charge is that the Government is anti-farmer and pro-corporate sector.

Of these, the charge that important party leaders opposed to Modi are being shadowed by state intelligence bureau sleuths carries weight. Mehta claims to have driven his car at breakneck speed only last month to chase two police constables who were shadowing him in Gandhinagar. They managed to get away. What the rebels don't state is that Modi, when he was not the chief minister, was himself shadowed by policemen.

There is little evidence to substantiate the charge that Modi has favoured industrialists by buying power at high rates. Under Modi, Gujarat became a revenue-surplus state after a gap of 15 years, and the power setup started making profit after suffering losses for years. Similarly, the charge that his Government is anti-farmer has no basis. Ever since Modi took over, Gujarat has registered an increase in crop production—due in part to successive good monsoons—surpassing past records. Dissidents cite the 405 farmer suicides in the state during Modi's reign, which, according to state agriculture department officials, were not because of poor agricultural return but were due entirely to social reasons.

Since June, when the rebel BJP leaders and Congressmen first shared a platform in Surat in the garb of a Patel meet, they have jointly addressed 75 public meetings, mostly in the rural areas of Saurashtra. The underlying theme of these sammelans, most of which were organised under the aegis of the Sardar Patel Utkarsh Samiti, a farmers' body, has been anti-Modi rhetoric. The rebels' base has been restricted to small pockets in Amreli, Junagadh, Jamnagar, Bhavnagar and Rajkot districts. In many gatherings,

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BLAME GAME

The dissidents accuse Modi of using the state police apparatus to shadow senior leaders. Last month, Suresh Mehta chased two constables who had been following him.

They say the Modi Government has favoured a handful of industrialists, including the Ambanis, the Ruia and Gautam Adani.

The rebels allege that the Modi Government has indulged in underhand dealings in the power and water conservation sectors.

Increasing farmer suicides in the state, according to the rebel faction, point to Modi's anti-farmer stance. The Government denies the charge.

the Congress played a pivotal role in organising crowds. The massive crowd at the meet in Rajkot last month was mainly organised by Congress MLA Vithal Radadiya, who heads the local co-operative bank network.

The strategy the rebels are putting together aims at roping in forces opposed to Modi who can dent his vote-bank, which is based on his developmental surge and his Hindutva image. They lost no time in roping in expelled BJP leader Uma Bharati, who announced: "I will campaign against Modi and expose his false Hindutva."

Modi's campaign, on the other

CHECK MATE: Modi is riding high on his development record

hand, appears to be in top gear. The rebels' association with the Congress will give him full room to portray them as ideological betrayers, a label that old BJP rebel and Union Textile Minister Shankarsinh Vaghela hasn't been able to shake off. As Gujarat BJP President Purshottam Rupala puts it, "After having talked about unalloyed nationalism all these years, the rebels are joining hands with the Congress and that too at a time when it appears to be the second version of the Muslim League. They are doomed." To add to their problems, there are indications that not everybody in the Congress is in favour of welcoming them aboard. On October 16, several activists signed a letter warning Sonia against admitting them into the party.

Challenging Modi might be a courageous thing to do, but the rebels' single-mindedness seems to suggest that they are using a public front to hide their personal grudges. Also, their caste arithmetic could go awry. Initially, the rebels had projected Modi as anti-Patel to target the Patel votes, but they soon realised that it would prove counter-productive and started portraying him as anti-farmer. This flip-flop can affect their credibility. Clearly, making a dent in Modi's votebank would not be an easy task, but things wouldn't be smooth for Modi either.